ONE-OFF SHIURIM

If God Is Good, Why Pray?

Derech Hashem 4:5:1-4

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 5, paragraphs 1-4 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 28 February 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

A new chapter: Tefillah

Part 4 is about the service of Hakadosh Barukh Hu. Besides Torah study, the misvot are divided into constant ones (like the love and fear of God), seasonal ones (like shofar), circumstantial ones (like mezuzah, which applies only if you own a house) and daily ones. Only two misvot are daily for everyone: Shema, which the class has just finished, and Tefillah.

This short chapter deals with prayer in general. The next chapter goes through the order of the prayers and why we say what we say.

The famous question

If God is good, He will give us the best whether or not we ask. A good father gives his children what is good for them without being asked. So what is the point of praying?

The Rabbi reminded the group of the approach he has taught in the past, that of Rabbi Yosef Albo in Sefer HaIkarim: prayer changes the person. His analogy is a patient and a doctor. The patient exercises and improves himself, and the same doctor now gives a different diagnosis. God has not changed; you have, and so His verdict for you changes. The Ramhal, he said, takes a different approach.

Drawing near (paragraph 1)

The Ramhal says that part of the order God set in creation is that for creatures to receive His goodness and abundance, they must awaken themselves, draw near to Him and ask of Him. The more they awaken and draw near, the more abundance comes; if they do not, they cannot draw it down.

So of course God is good and wants to give us good, but He wants us to draw near to Him, and for that He created prayer. This also explains why prayer is an obligation. If prayer were only for my benefit, I could decide whether I want the benefit. But God wants us to have the best, so He made prayer obligatory, so that we bring down the shefa, the flow of blessing.

Do people who pray get more?

A participant asked whether, at our level, we can see any difference between people who pray and people who do not. The Rabbi said this is really a form of the question from Part 2 of why the righteous suffer and the wicked prosper. Another participant answered that a person who does not pray may still receive, but he lacks the relationship. And if the link were obvious, there would be no free choice: "You can pray now, you can get it ten years from now." It has to be concealed.

During this exchange a participant spoke about the news of that week concerning the Jews of Ukraine, and the need for emunah when we cannot understand what is happening. "If you don't have emunah, you can forget about it all."

The danger of the mundane (paragraph 2)

The Ramhal then gives a deeper reason. God gave us the burden of looking after our own lives and livelihood for two reasons:

1. Our honour and self-respect. Being able to earn a living by the sweat of one's brow is precious.
2. More importantly, to keep us connected to the mundane world, which human beings need. As learned in Part 1, there must be a balance between dark and light, mundane and holy, body and soul.

Being involved in the mundane is a descent, but a necessary one, and it leads to a greater ascent. If we engage with the world with the right motives, we elevate it, and end higher than before. "We human beings who do well, we're higher than angels."

But there is a danger: the more a person becomes entangled in worldly matters, the further he moves from the light. How do we stop ourselves sinking?

Prayer first thing in the morning

God created a remedy. Every day, before becoming entangled in the world, a person first attaches himself to God, asks Him for all his needs and casts his burden on Him. Then, when he goes about the ordinary human ways of making a living, he does not sink so deep, because he prefaced his day by recognising that it all comes from God.

That is why Shaharit should be the first thing a person does. "You don't go to work for two hours and then pray Shaharit." By drawing near to God first, you see the whole physical world from a different angle. You are still immersed in it, but you recognise what is behind it.

The Rabbi summarised the Ramhal's two reasons:

1. God wants us near Him, and so tied the abundance He gives to our prayer, and made prayer obligatory.
2. Prayer stops us becoming totally entangled in the mundane.

(There was a brief detour into whether the English word is "mundaneness" or "mundanity".)

A great kindness and three steps back (paragraphs 3-4)

The very fact that we can pray is a great kindness. Even in our natural state, sunk in darkness, God has given us the right to call His name, to rise from our lowliness and come close to Him. Because of this closeness, prayer, which always means the Amidah, is so severe: one may not interrupt it at all.

That is also why there is a departure at the end, the three steps back. It marks the return to one's ordinary state. God does not want us in prayer all day; He wants us involved in the world, taking stock three times a day.

The Gemara says the early hasidim would wait some time before prayer and some time after. The Rabbi explained why after: "I can't just go back to my phone calls now." Just as after a football game your body needs ten minutes to calm down before a meeting, so too after a spiritual encounter. It is very hard to reach that level, but that is the aim, and the steps back symbolise the return to the mundane.

Paragraph 4 says that Hazal taught all the laws of prayer around these ideas of drawing near and bringing down blessing. They also arranged prayer to make up for the lack of daily sacrifices, which is the subject of the next chapter.

Summary

- Rabbi Yosef Albo says prayer changes the person; the Ramhal says God made His abundance depend on our drawing near.
- Prayer is obligatory because God wants to give us good.
- The link between prayer and blessing must stay hidden, or there would be no free choice.
- Earning a living keeps us in the mundane world; praying first thing each morning stops us from sinking into it.
- Being able to pray is a great kindness, which is why the Amidah is never interrupted and ends with three steps back.

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